

STAGE FIVE • THINKING, REASONING & MENTAL MODELS

# FIRSTS

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## SESSION PLAN

*Four sessions, mapped and timed, to run all 30 FIRSTS as a live workshop*

A Citrus Edition Facilitator Resource • Companion to the FIRSTS Manual

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# FIRSTS • Session Plan

Stage Five • Thinking, Reasoning & Mental Models

## OVERVIEW

Stage Five's thirty FIRSTS are split across four sessions: Foundational Mental Models and Applied Reasoning & Reflection (the source category G), then Advanced Frameworks I and II (the source category H). Each session pairs a short facilitator-led framing with independent worksheet time, applying each tool to a real, current problem rather than a hypothetical one.

This stage is more cognitively demanding than most — nearly every FIRST asks for genuine written reasoning, not just reflection. Build in slightly more independent work time per FIRST than earlier stages, and resist the temptation to rush through frameworks that feel simple to explain but take real time to apply well.

## AT A GLANCE

| Time      | Segment                                 | Format   |
|-----------|-----------------------------------------|----------|
| Session 1 | Foundational Mental Models — G1-G8      | ~125 min |
| Session 2 | Applied Reasoning & Reflection — G9-G15 | ~115 min |
| Session 3 | Advanced Frameworks I — H16-H23         | ~130 min |
| Session 4 | Advanced Frameworks II — H24-H30        | ~115 min |

## SESSION 1

### Foundational Mental Models

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*Covers FIRSTS G1-G8: Mental Model Awareness, Cause-and-Effect Mapping, Problem Breakdown Exercise, Decision Matrix, Root Cause Analysis, Critical Thinking Drill, Hypothesis Testing, Scenario Planning.*

## PRE-WORK

- No advance preparation required. Ask participants to bring one real, current decision or problem they're genuinely facing — this stage works best applied to real situations, not hypotheticals.

## SESSION AGENDA

| Time      | Segment                                                                | Format                            |
|-----------|------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------|
| 0:00-0:10 | Welcome + framing: this stage gives you tools, not just self-knowledge | Full group                        |
| 0:10-0:30 | FIRST G1 — Mental Model Awareness                                      | Solo, then quick full-group share |
| 0:30-0:50 | FIRST G2 — Cause-and-Effect Mapping                                    | Solo                              |
| 0:50-1:10 | FIRST G3 — Problem Breakdown Exercise                                  | Solo                              |
| 1:10-1:15 | Short break                                                            | —                                 |

|           |                                              |                             |
|-----------|----------------------------------------------|-----------------------------|
| 1:15-1:40 | FIRST G4 — Decision Matrix                   | Solo                        |
| 1:40-2:00 | FIRST G5 — Root Cause Analysis               | Solo                        |
| 2:00-2:20 | FIRST G6 — Critical Thinking Drill           | Solo                        |
| 2:20-2:40 | FIRST G7 — Hypothesis Testing                | Solo                        |
| 2:40-3:05 | FIRST G8 — Scenario Planning + session close | Solo, then full-group close |

#### FACILITATOR NOTES

- This session is long; consider a second short break around the two-hour mark if energy is visibly flagging.
- Every FIRST in this session works best applied to something real — keep redirecting participants back to their own actual problem rather than a generic textbook example.

## SESSION 2

# Applied Reasoning & Reflection

Covers *FIRSTS G9–G15: Cognitive Bias Audit, Systems Thinking Exercise, Feedback Integration, Strategic Prioritization, Mental Model Application, Pattern Recognition Drill, Reflection on Decision-Making.*

### PRE-WORK

- Ask participants to bring to mind one piece of real feedback they've received recently, for use in FIRST G11.

### SESSION AGENDA

| Time      | Segment                                                                          | Format                      |
|-----------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------|
| 0:00–0:10 | Welcome + bridge: session 1 gave individual tools, today integrates and reflects | Full group                  |
| 0:10–0:30 | FIRST G9 — Cognitive Bias Audit                                                  | Solo                        |
| 0:30–0:55 | FIRST G10 — Systems Thinking Exercise                                            | Solo                        |
| 0:55–1:15 | FIRST G11 — Feedback Integration                                                 | Solo                        |
| 1:15–1:20 | Short break                                                                      | —                           |
| 1:20–1:40 | FIRST G12 — Strategic Prioritization                                             | Solo                        |
| 1:40–2:05 | FIRST G13 — Mental Model Application                                             | Solo                        |
| 2:05–2:25 | FIRST G14 — Pattern Recognition Drill                                            | Solo                        |
| 2:25–2:45 | FIRST G15 — Reflection on Decision-Making + session close                        | Solo, then full-group close |

### FACILITATOR NOTES

- FIRST G13 (Mental Model Application) is a deliberate checkpoint tying together everything from Session 1 — give it genuine room rather than rushing it.
- This closes out the G category; use the session close to explicitly name the shift into H (more advanced frameworks) starting next session.

### SESSION 3

## Advanced Frameworks I

*Covers FIRSTS H16-H23: SWOT Thinking Exercise, First-Principles Analysis, Inversion Thinking Drill, Opportunity Cost Exercise, 80/20 Analysis, Systems Thinking Application, Decision Tree Exercise, Scenario Analysis.*

#### PRE-WORK

- Ask participants to identify one real, complex, multi-step decision they're currently facing or expect to face soon, for use across several FIRSTS this session.

#### SESSION AGENDA

| Time      | Segment                                                                                           | Format                                                        |
|-----------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------|
| 0:00-0:10 | Welcome + framing: today's frameworks extend Session 1-2's foundations to higher-stakes decisions | Full group                                                    |
| 0:10-0:30 | FIRST H16 — SWOT Thinking Exercise                                                                | Solo                                                          |
| 0:30-0:55 | FIRST H17 — First-Principles Analysis                                                             | Solo                                                          |
| 0:55-1:15 | FIRST H18 — Inversion Thinking Drill                                                              | Solo                                                          |
| 1:15-1:20 | Short break                                                                                       | —                                                             |
| 1:20-1:40 | FIRST H19 — Opportunity Cost Exercise                                                             | Solo                                                          |
| 1:40-2:00 | FIRST H20 — 80/20 Analysis                                                                        | Solo                                                          |
| 2:00-2:25 | FIRST H21 — Systems Thinking Application                                                          | Solo or small groups if applied to a real shared team problem |
| 2:25-2:50 | FIRST H22 — Decision Tree Exercise                                                                | Solo                                                          |
| 2:50-3:10 | FIRST H23 — Scenario Analysis + session close                                                     | Solo, then full-group close                                   |

#### FACILITATOR NOTES

- This is the longest session in the stage; consider splitting it across two shorter sittings if your cohort's attention flags past two hours.
- FIRST H21 can genuinely work as a small-group exercise if participants share a real team context (classmates on a shared project, colleagues); otherwise keep it solo, applied to a team they're part of outside this room.

## SESSION 4

### Advanced Frameworks II

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*Covers FIRSTS H24–H30: Checklists & SOPs Creation, Root Cause Framework, Feedback Loop Exercise, Comparative Analysis, Mental Model Combination, Hypothesis-Driven Approach, Strategic Mapping.*

#### PRE-WORK

- Ask participants to identify one task they perform repeatedly (school, work, or personal) that could benefit from a written checklist, for use in FIRST H24.

#### SESSION AGENDA

| Time      | Segment                                                                                         | Format                      |
|-----------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------|
| 0:00–0:10 | Welcome + framing: closing out with the frameworks that make reasoning repeatable and sustained | Full group                  |
| 0:10–0:30 | FIRST H24 — Checklists & SOPs Creation                                                          | Solo                        |
| 0:30–0:50 | FIRST H25 — Root Cause Framework                                                                | Solo                        |
| 0:50–1:10 | FIRST H26 — Feedback Loop Exercise                                                              | Solo                        |
| 1:10–1:15 | Short break                                                                                     | —                           |
| 1:15–1:35 | FIRST H27 — Comparative Analysis                                                                | Solo                        |
| 1:35–2:00 | FIRST H28 — Mental Model Combination                                                            | Solo                        |
| 2:00–2:20 | FIRST H29 — Hypothesis-Driven Approach                                                          | Solo                        |
| 2:20–2:45 | FIRST H30 — Strategic Mapping + stage close                                                     | Solo, then full-group close |

#### FACILITATOR NOTES

- FIRST H30 is the capstone of the entire stage, combining prioritization, systems thinking, and scenario planning into one integrated map — give it genuine room rather than rushing it if earlier segments ran long.
- Close the full stage by having each participant share one specific mental model or framework from across all thirty FIRSTS they intend to keep using deliberately, not just the most recent one.
- This is a natural moment to preview Stage Six (Communication), which relies heavily on the clear thinking built in this stage.